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How buying off-plan actually works

Buying off-plan in Dubai is a regulated, escrow-protected process — but it moves fast at launch, and knowing the sequence in advance is the difference between choosing a unit and being sold one.

1 **Brief & budget.** We agree what the money needs to do — growth or income — your ceiling, and your exit horizon. This happens before any brochure is opened.

2 **Expression of Interest (EOI).** A refundable deposit (typically AED 20,000–100,000 depending on the project) registers you for a launch and sets your place in the queue for unit selection.

3 **Launch day & allocation.** Units are released against the EOI queue. You confirm from the real price sheet — unit, floor, view, exact price — not from the marketing render.

4 **Booking & down payment.** You sign the booking form and pay the down payment (usually 10–20%), plus the 4% Dubai Land Department fee and admin charges.

5 **SPA — the Sale & Purchase Agreement.** The full contract: specification, floor plan, payment schedule, completion date and compensation terms. This is the document worth reading twice; we go through it with you.

6 **Oqood registration.** Your purchase is registered with the DLD in the interim register — your legal record of ownership while the building goes up.

7 **Staged payments — into escrow.** Instalments follow the plan in the SPA (e.g. 1% a month, or construction milestones). By law they go into a RERA-supervised escrow account the developer can only draw against verified construction progress.

8 **Handover.** Snagging inspection, final payment, title deed issued, keys. If it's a rental, furnishing and lettings start here — we can arrange both through our partners.

THE CHOICE UNDERNEATH EVERY DUBAI PURCHASE

Off-plan or ready?

	OFF-PLAN (NEW LAUNCH)	READY (BUILT & TITLED)
WHAT YOU PAY NOW	10–20% down, then instalments over 2–5 years. Capital is committed gradually.	Full price at transfer (or mortgage deposit). Capital committed on day one.
PRICE OF ENTRY	Market median AED 1,762/sq ft — launches now price at a premium to the built city, not a discount.	Market median AED 1,484/sq ft. You can negotiate; sellers are people, not price sheets.
INCOME	None until handover — typically 2–4 years of no rent.	Rent from week one. Yields currently 4.4–8.3% gross depending on area.
GROWTH CASE	You buy tomorrow's building at today's price with a payment plan — leverage without a mortgage. Strongest when the developer and location are right.	You buy what you can see, inspect and let immediately. Growth tracks the area, not a promise.
KEY RISKS	Completion delay; the market at handover, not at launch; developer quality. Mitigated by RERA escrow, DLD registration — and above all by developer selection.	You inherit the building's age, service-charge history and tenancy market as they are. What you see is what you get — both ways.
EXIT	Resale ("assignment") usually allowed after 30–40% is paid — some plans restrict earlier flips.	Sell any time; standard transfer.
WHO IT SUITS	Growth investors who don't need income yet and can commit to the instalment schedule.	Income investors, and anyone who wants keys — or a visa — now.

73% of Dubai's 2026 purchases are off-plan. That is not proof it's right for you — it is proof the launches are where the market's attention is. We work both sides of the line and will tell you which fits your brief.

FOR UK-BASED INVESTORS

Dubai next to the UK, honestly

	UK BUY-TO-LET	DUBAI
PURCHASE TAX	SDLT with the 5% additional-property surcharge — on a £250k rental that's roughly £15,000.	4% DLD transfer fee plus small admin charges — on the same money, roughly £10,000.
TAX ON RENT	Income tax at 20–45%; mortgage interest relief restricted.	No UAE income tax. **But:** UK residents pay UK tax on worldwide rental income — the UAE advantage is fully realised only if your tax residence moves. Take advice.
TAX ON SALE	CGT at 24% on residential gains.	No UAE capital gains tax; same UK-residence caveat applies.
YIELDS	Typically 5–8% gross on the value strategies we run (BRR, serviced accommodation, social housing).	4.4–8.3% gross by area; short-let (holiday) operation can run higher, with operating costs to match.
FINANCING	Deep mortgage market; leverage is the UK's superpower.	Non-resident mortgages exist (typically 50–60% LTV) but off-plan payment plans replace debt for most overseas buyers.
RUNNING COSTS	Maintenance, compliance, licensing, management — and they're rising.	Annual service charges (budget AED 15–30/sq ft in prime towers); management 5–15%.
CURRENCY	Sterling in, sterling out.	AED is pegged to the US dollar — you are taking a considered dollar position against sterling.
THE HONEST SUMMARY	Better leverage, income you can engineer, a legal system you know — and heavier tax at every stage.	Lighter transaction and holding costs, launch payment plans, residency routes — and a younger market that rewards developer selection and punishes brochure-buying.

We invest in both. The right answer is usually a question — what do you need the money to do, and when? That's the fifteen-minute conversation.

RESIDENCY THROUGH PROPERTY

The visa, in plain terms

10-year Golden Visa

Own property worth **AED 2 million+** (≈£420k) recorded at the DLD. Can be one property or several combined; off-plan and mortgaged property can qualify (with proof of AED 2m paid, for mortgages). Freehold areas only. Renewable, family sponsorship included, no minimum stay beyond periodic visits.

2-year investor residency

The traditional route for smaller holdings (historically AED 750k+). From April 2026 Dubai relaxed the minimum for fully-owned property — making residency accessible at lower entry points. Requirements are checked case-by-case at application.

Immigration rules change and are applied case-by-case — we confirm the current position with the developer and a registered agent before you commit, never after.

BEFORE YOU FLY

Visiting Dubai to view

When. October to April is the season — 25–32°C. June to September is 40°C+; viewings still run, everything is air-conditioned, flights and hotels are cheaper.

Getting in. UK passports get a free 30–40 day visa on arrival. The weekend is Saturday–Sunday; government offices close then.

Getting around. Careem/Uber everywhere and cheap; the Metro covers the Marina–Downtown spine. Allow 45 minutes between viewings — Dubai distances deceive.

Viewing days. Bring your passport — sales centres register visitors. Two or three projects a day maximum if you want to actually think. Sales suites are theatre; ask for the price sheet and the service-charge figure.

Money. Cards everywhere. If you commit while out there, deposits are paid by card or transfer — never cash, and never to a personal account.

Manner. Dubai is easy-going but it is not Ibiza — dress smart-casual at sales centres and hotels and you'll be treated accordingly. During Ramadan, eat and drink discreetly in public by day.

Planning a viewing trip? We'll build the itinerary around your brief.

15 MINUTES, NO PITCH · SAMNHARV.CO.UK/CALL

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